about it, and what plans we had.' Honecker's prison misdemeanours were not mentioned, but after a long chat, Ulbricht felt he had the right sort of experience to offer him the daunting assignment of working out a framework for a youth organisation. As several associates gave approving nods, the old man talked for another hour, ending – as he put it – with 'a call for action'. After the meeting, with the help of Ulbricht's contacts, Honecker was able to make a surprise visit to Wiebelskirchen for a family reunion, which 'after more than ten years away was indescribably great'. His weight had fallen sharply. His sister remembered being shocked by his gaunt appearance, leading to his mother cooking him three hearty meals a day. The rest and relaxation at home proved a pleasure, a splendid diversion from the filth and desolation of Berlin. 'We had a lot to tell each other, but unfortunately, we didn't have enough time. Just a few days later I had to start my return journey.'5

At first, the Soviet occupiers seemed to be advocating a form of democracy by allowing old parties to resurface, including a reformed Christian Democrat Union (CDU), Social Democrats (SPD) and the Liberals (LDP). This, however, was a premeditated plan to legitimise the organisation and promotion of the KPD. But to Ulbricht's distress, because of its close links with Moscow, the KPD failed to gain public support as indignation continued at the extent of Russian raping and pillaging that accompanied the occupation. Concerns about the electability of the KPD worsened after elections in Hungary and Austria saw the communists record dire results.

In an effort to solve the problem, the Soviets identified a natural sympathy between the KPD and the more-popular SPD (which emerged as a significant rival in the eastern zone) and pushed for a merger. However, the proposal suffered a humiliating setback in a West Berlin referendum (the Russians prevented it in theirs) where SPD members crushingly rejected merging by more than six to one. However, after months of coercion and intimidation, SPD representatives finally accepted a merger to create the Sozialistische Einheitspartei Deutschlands (SED). The union was cemented on 21 April 1946 at the Admiralspalast, opposite the Friedrichstraße railway station. 'We all rose from our seats enthusiastically and sang the Internationale,' Honecker remembered. The newly fused party, with the